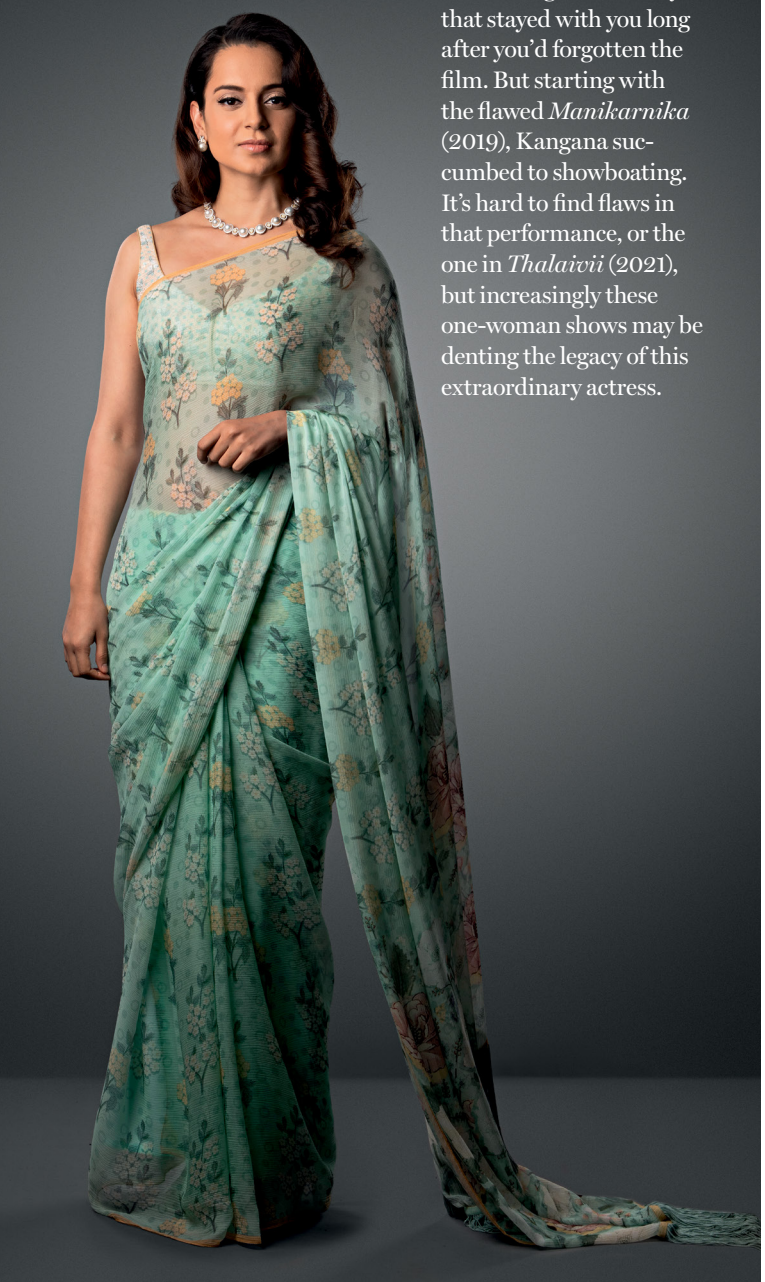
Kangana Ranaut

Although it wasn't until that full-bodied, winning performance in *Queen* (2013) that she actually made it, Kangana had begun laying the foundation through impressive performances in the noughties—*Gangster*, *Woh Lamhe*, *Fashion*, and then *Tanu Weds Manu* (2011). Slowly, a range came into view, instantly likeable characters breaking the stereotype of highly strung, neurotic women that she'd been boxed into. Even in middling fare like *Simran* (2017), she brought a charming authenticity that stayed with you long after you'd forgotten the film. But starting with the flawed *Manikarnika* (2019), Kangana succumbed to showboating. It's hard to find flaws in that performance, or the one in *Thalaivii* (2021), but increasingly these one-woman shows may be denting the legacy of this extraordinary actress.



BANDEEP SINGH

BANDEEP SINGH



Alia Bhatt

She's not even 30 and she's on top of it. In just 10 years after a forgettable debut (*Student of the Year*, 2012), Alia has revealed a genius gift for sucking us into her world, most recently as the you-can't-take-your-eyes-off-her *Gangubai Kathiawadi* (2022). Remember the heart-breaking awkwardness of her first 'pose' as a sex worker, to years later, her resigned wisdom while she unchains a young girl—the beauty of her jaded words seduce you. Alia has prodigious talent. It's there when she breaks a bottle in jealous rage in *Gully Boy* (2019), as she lies drugged, gang-raped, with vacant eyes in *Udta Punjab* (2016), or as she points a gun at the man she loves, her identity unmasked, love battling with duty, in *Raazi* (2018). She has a child-like air and yet every performance is mature. How will Alia Bhatt surprise us in the years to come? Thankfully, we can wait...and watch.